

Framing “Female Terrorists:” Newspapers and Their Reporting Impact in the Cases of Idoia Lopez Riano, Siti Aisyah and Doan Thi Huong, and Boko Haram

Abstract

Female terrorists have become an increasingly common phenomenon in recent years as even terrorist groups that used to retained from deploying female terrorists began using them for strategic purposes. Subsequently, news media coverage on female terrorists also became a more prevalent issue as frames demonstrating gender stereotypes emerge in these reports. This paper continues to explore on how gender stereotypes are presented in news report on female terrorists through analyzing the cases of Idoia Lopez Riano, Siti Aisyah and Doan Thi Huong, and Boko Haram’s female suicide bombers. Through framing theory, articles in English, Spanish, French, Korean, and Chinese were scrutinized. The examination reveals four new frames: sexual bait frame, narcissistic women frame, dangerous, trained female assassin frame, and duped and manipulated by vanity frame while finding evidence for previous found frames. This paper adds on to the existing literature on media frames surrounding female terrorists and argues that the readers have been influenced by these frames in their understanding of female terrorists.

Keywords: *Female terrorists, media frames theory, gender stereotypes, terrorism*

1. Introduction: The Rise of Female Terrorism from the 1980s to Present Day

Women have long been protagonists in political and religious conflicts. In particular, the role of women in major terrorist events has flourished in more recent years. As the history of women’s studies is quite young, not much information about female terrorists can be found in traditional sources; however, “A Dictionary of Gender Studies,” a book published to cover the emerging field of gender, explored the topic, defining “female terrorists” as women who participated in “military and combat activities” that aim for liberation or overthrowing local dictatorships or occupying forces (Griffen, 2017).

Initially, in terrorist groups, women played supporting personnel roles in logistics, intelligence, recruitment, and propaganda departments (Raghavan & Balasubramaniyan, 2014). However, as security and defense mechanisms for counter-terrorism acts strengthened, terrorist groups accepted women as important leading figures in their plots and goals. Today, these female terrorists play a variety of roles in terrorist groups such as collaborators, informers, human shields, recruiters, sexual bait, and perpetrators of violence (Berko & Erez, 2007).

Since the 1980s, the roles that women have played in acts of terrorism and assassinations have increased. The upsurge in the number of female bombers within terrorist groups (Bloom, 2007) appears to correspond with increasing strategic needs for female terrorists. Female suicide bombers were involved in 71 attacks in 2017; this number increased from their involvement in three attacks in 1998. According to Joan Cook and Gina Vale (2018), women comprise as much as 13 percent of all those who are affiliated with the self-proclaimed Islamic State (IS) in Iraq and Syria, although they may be undercounted because there is a lack of accurate data.

Some of the most notable female terrorist groups include the “Black Tigers” in Sri Lanka and the “Black Widows” in Chechnya; individual standout female terrorists include Idoia López Riaño, a hit woman nicknamed The Tigress who belongs to the ETA (short for Euskadi Ta Askatasuna, which translates to “Basque Homeland and Liberty”), and the British jihadist Samantha Lewthwaite, nicknamed “White Widow,” who was accused of taking more than 400 lives.

The following literature review explores how sociologists, political scientists, and historians study female terrorists around the world and how these female terrorists have been portrayed by the media over the last 20 years. Frame analysis was utilized while organizing existing frames about female terrorists and proposing four new frames that have not yet been named. This paper then looks at three different cases of women involved in terrorism: Idoia López Riaño of ETA in the 1980s, Siti Aisyah and Doan Thi Huong in the murder of Kim Jong Nam case in 2017, and the female suicide bombers of Boko Haram in Nigeria (active since 2014). This paper examines how the media reported each aforementioned case (specifically, how the media represented certain framings and stereotypes about women and female terrorists) and

how the reporting about these women was dangerous. The majority of the analyzed articles were in English but also news reports in Spanish, French, Korean, and Chinese were examined. In all three cases of female terrorism, both domestic and also international newspapers were scrutinized.

2. Media Misconceptions of Female Terrorists

Some saw the rise of female terrorism as surprising, as women are most commonly seen as peacemakers and caretakers rather than murderers or destroyers (Wickham et al., 2018). The media began its coverage of female terrorists with Sana'a Mehaydali, the first female bomber seen as a suicidal martyr in 1985.

As of 2007, major news outlets, such as the *New York Times* and *Reuters*, had focused much attention on the coverage of male terrorists in Germany, Iraq, and Greece. Notable researchers began to take note of this reporting phenomenon and explore why. Mia Bloom, a professor at Georgia State University who specializes in female terrorism, aimed to explain the reporting trends about female terrorists in a 2007 study. Though the majority of suicide bombers at the time were male, Bloom found that female bombers received an average of eight times more media attention than their male counterparts (Bloom, 2007). In the same article by Bloom, the author hypothesized that this increased media attention was because the images taken of female terrorists were often deadly and hideous. Bloom also hypothesized that when female terrorists appeared in the news, the general public was shocked and therefore turned more attention to them. In their books, *Mothers, Monsters, Whores: Women's Violence in Global Politics*, two researchers who specialize in gender studies and conflicts, Gentry and Sioberg (2015), agreed with Bloom's idea, as they also found readers were shocked when they ingested reporting about female terrorists.

Media Framing Theory, which was first posited in 1972 by anthropologist Gregory Bateson, argues that the media packages and presents information to the public with frames that encourage or discourage certain interpretations. Over the past few decades, a number of frames have arisen to explain the media's portrayal of female terrorists. All of the frames encourage a biased and one-sided view of female terrorism. While the following review explores and

summarizes some of these frames, the full explanation of all the frames mentioned in this paper can be found in Appendix A.

Brigitte Nacos (2005), the author of several books related to mass media and terrorism, categorized the frames set for female terrorists in media into the following six categories: 1) The physical appearance frame that focuses on female terrorists' appearances in reports; 2) The "family connection" frame that focuses on female terrorists' family background; 3) The "terrorist for the sake of love" frame that emphasizes female terrorists' romantic relationships; 4) The "women's lib/equality" frame that portrays female terrorists' activities as the consequence of women's liberation movements; 5) The "tough-as-males/tougher-than-men" frame that depicts female terrorists as not *real* women; 6) The "bored, naïve, out-of-touch-with-reality" frame that describes female terrorists as "non-political and clueless [about their actions]." Nacos looked at more than 60 articles as she conducted her research and found all frames were biased.

Five other frames were raised by Pierce (2011) about the female suicide bombers in Chechnya known as the "Black Widows" and Afghan self-immolators: 7) The "feminized imagery" frame that represents female terrorists as "others" with headlines, photographs, and descriptive vernaculars; 8) The "violence breeds violence" frame that uses environmental factors to rationalize female terrorists' actions; 9) The "Islamic honor" frame that uses religious ideologies to justify female terrorists' actions; 10) The "manipulation and male control" frame that focuses on women being pawns of men and susceptible to manipulation; 11) The "irrational women" frame that posits that female irrationality underpins female terrorists' actions. Again, in Pierce's research, she found that frames leaned completely towards the reinforcement of gender stereotypes and provided a biased representation of female terrorists.

Psychologists Hien La and Selena Pickett (2019) from Miami University also raised two frames regarding Boko Haram's female suicide bombers, namely 12) the "liable agent" frame that deems female terrorists personally responsible for their actions, and 13) the "vulnerable and helpless girl" frame that argues that female terrorists' are forced into their roles with no control

over their actions. Once again, researchers found a single-sided narrative damaging to women through the frames they studied.

These frames are not just theoretical; they can be seen in modern-day media coverage of female terrorists.

Maura Conway and Lisa McInerney of Dublin City University and the University of Limerick conducted a study in 2012 about the media reporting of Colleen LaRose, more widely known as “Jihad Jane,” and her two fellow male terrorists. The three were arrested in the United States in 2009 and 2010 for participating in jihadi terrorist plots. When comparing how the media portrayed LaRose and her male accomplices, the study found four of Nacos’s frames to be prevalent. There were significantly more reports about LaRose’s physical appearance, family and romantic relationships, and her troubled past than those of her male counterparts. This study added to the body of evidence that female terrorists are represented by frames built upon stereotypes.

Conway and McInerney are not the only ones who have looked into recent reporting on female terrorists. Naaman (2007) analyzed reports of Wafa Idris, the first Palestinian female suicide bomber, who detonated herself in Jerusalem in 2002, and put forward the frames 14) “monsters” and 15) “brides.” The media portrayed Wafa Idris as a monster: an unhappy woman who no longer saw hope to live because she was infertile. Again, biased reporting remained.

3. The Danger of Frames

These frames and stereotypes are underestimating the level of involvement women have in terrorism (Wickham et al., 2019). These frames are dangerous for four reasons.

First, the misreporting of women’s motivations by the media creates more societal damage in terms of the number of acts of terrorism carried out. Many terrorist groups exploit the media’s stereotypes and frames to suit their strategic needs for carrying out acts of violence (Bloom, 2007). For example, these stereotypes about women benefit terrorist groups’ deployment of female bombers, as they reduce the security’s vigilance of women (Figchel, 2003). Speckhard

(2008) pointed out that female terrorists, considered unthreatening, are more likely to be trusted by security and therefore less likely to be searched. Speckhard also found that it is often uncomfortable for security personnel to search women thoroughly, regardless of the gender of the security personnel, leaving loopholes for female bombers. In 2006, the members of the LTTE also disguised their suicide belts as pregnancies to avoid being searched at the checkpoints.

Additionally, because of biased media coverage, terrorist groups have a way to leverage more media attention by using women. As female terrorists receive eight times more media attention than male terrorists (Bloom, 2007), terrorist groups employ women to create a greater shock and put forward a stronger statement to the media.

The media's extensive portrayal of female terrorists also enables terrorist groups to increase their recruitment. Women, portrayed as mothers, wives, and caretakers, help convey the message that terrorist causes as "a cause everyone should support (not just a group of violent men)" (Wickham et al., 2019). Zarqawi, a chief commander of Al-Qaeda, also used female terrorists to shame men into joining his cause throughout time.

Finally, these media frames are damaging to women's empowerment. The media's stereotypes focusing on women's appearances, their emotions, and their connections with men only add to the general trend of a one-sided, disempowered portrayal of women. The stereotyping of women in news reports is helping to perpetuate underrepresentation, gender stereotypes, and discrimination against women (Mateos de Cabo et al., 2014).

4. Results and Discussions

4.1 The Case of Idoia López Riaño

Idoia López Riaño is a former hit woman for ETA, (short for Euskadi Ta Askatasuna or the Basque Homeland and Liberty), an armed group that fought for the separation of the Basque Country from Spain from 1959 to 2017 when they finally ceased operations. During their active years, ETA engaged in bombings, assassinations, and kidnapping.

Riaño joined ETA in 1984 when she was eighteen, and she committed her first crime that November. She actively participated in terrorism activities since joining ETA and took part

in attacks such as the bombing of the Plaza República Dominicana, which was one of her most destructive operations, in Madrid on July 14, 1986. This attack killed 12 people and injured another 32 people. She started to gain a reputation from those killings and later became a lieutenant in ETA.

Riaño was caught in France in 1994 and transferred to a detention center in Spain in 2001; there, she was tried as an ETA member and charged with the murder of 23 people. She was sentenced to 1,572 years in prison, but she was released in 2017 after expressing remorse for her crimes, ultimately serving only 23 years in prison.

4.1.1 How the Media Represented Riaño

The media showed great interest in Riaño's physical appearance and sexuality since she first made her splash in the media in the 1980s. She was first given the nickname "La Tigressa" for her sexual prowess by the Spanish press around that time. After she was arrested in France, she was described as a "tall, slim, green-eyed woman with a shock of curly black hair" in the *Times* of London (Owen, 1994). The reporter also noted that she was "criticized for being trigger-happy, refusing to let only male comrades open fire" and considered "a security risk" by ETA "because of her passion for stalking young men in city discos at night." Anne McElvoy, also in the *Times* (1995), reported that Riaño "has the looks of a Mediterranean film star, and mythical sexual prowess." She also described Riaño as "more animated, wearing hefty eye make-up, fuchsia lipstick and dangling earrings that tinkle as she tosses her head of black curls." As Riaño was being tried in Spain, Antonella Lazzeri described her as "beautiful" in *The Sun* (2001).

Reports reached a peak when Riaño openly expressed her sorrow and remorse for the crimes that she committed in 2011. The headline for *The Daily Telegraph's* report was "How 'The Tigress' turned into a pussy cat" and the subsequent article began by writing about how Riaño "lured policemen into her bed, then calmly pumped bullets into their colleagues" (2011). Lee Moran also started the article in the *Sunday Times* of London by stating that Riaño was "ETA's

green-eyed femme fatale” and “dubbed La Tigresa (The Tigress) for her legendary sexual prowess” (2011).

Riaño wrote a letter asking for forgiveness from the families of the victims in 2016. Yet, the reporting on her continued to emphasize her sexuality. In 2016, the *Times* of London depicted Riaño as an “ETA sexual tigress” in their headline and started their report by writing “she was known for her bed-hopping antics with policemen before she murdered their comrades in the name of the Basque separatist group Eta” (Keeley, 2016). The *Times* did it again in 2017 when Riaño was released early for a letter of remorse, bringing up how she was seducing and sleeping with policemen twice in their reports on how families of victims condemned her early release (Keeley, 2017).

Since Riaño’s release in 2017, the media attention has continued focusing on her looks and vanity. *The Mirror* noted how “Juan Manuel Soares Gamboa, a former member of the Madrid unit, described Riaño as a ‘slave of her body and hair’” (Sharpe & Couzens, 2020). They also quote Gamboa’s description of Riaño: “When you’re with *La Tigresa* you’re not traveling with just her but with her 500 ways and forms of attracting attention.” The nickname for her in the media also changed from The Tigress to “Real-life Villanelle.” Another article from the *Daily Mirror* described female killers as “more ruthless and sexually beguiling than their fictional counterparts” (“Real Femme,” 2020). This description included Riaño.

Some reports on Riaño in recent years are about how she inspired the hit series *Killing Eve*. Luke Jennings, the author of the book *Codename Villanelle* (2018), on which the series is based, confirmed this suspicion. When talking about how he took inspiration from Riaño, he even went on to describe her vanity: “an ETA member had told of a stakeout they were on, with a view to killing a police officer when Riaño missed her chance because she was too busy admiring her own reflection” (Perry, 2020).

4.1.2 Frames and Stereotypes Behind the Reports and Why They Can Be Dangerous

The frame behind the majority of these reports is noted by Brigitte Nacos (2005) as the physical appearance frame. This is clear as the media described Riaño's physical appearance—her eye color and her hair—in almost all the articles this paper looked at.

The media also clearly emphasized Riaño's sexual experience with policemen and her excessive attention on her appearance. In doing so, they used the "sexual bait" frame, which is based on the stereotype about women using sex to appeal to men and how women should not be eager for sexual relationships with males but instead keep pure and abstain from sex unless asked by men (Wickham et al., 2019). The second frame, summarized as "narcissistic women," is based on the stereotypes about how women pay a lot of attention to their appearance and outfits, and how that attention distracts women from their jobs (Cash & Brown, 1989).

The media also portrayed Riaño as a slut, which, as Gentry and Sjoberg stated in their book *Beyond Mothers, Monsters, Whores* (2015), is blaming women's violence on the evils of female sexuality.

These frames used to describe Riaño are dangerous because they paint female terrorists as mysterious and fascinating rather than threatening and murderous. Riaño's fictional counterpart, Villanelle, is widely admired by viewers because of her beauty, cold-heartedness, and intelligence. On Rotten Tomatoes, viewers describe Villanelle as brilliant, clever, enjoyable, and talented.

4.2 The Case of Siti Aisyah and Doan Thi Huong

Siti Aisyah from Indonesia and Doan Thi Huong from Vietnam are the two direct suspects in the murder of Kim Jong Nam, the half-brother of the North Korean President, in Malaysia. The assassination took place in Kuala Lumpur International Airport on February 13th, 2017. Kim Jong Nam died due to VX nerve agent, which was rubbed on his face by Aisyah and Huong. The two women were identified through surveillance cameras and were taken into custody a few days after Kim Jong Nam's death.

Aisyah and Huong were charged with murder, which could have resulted in the death penalty in Malaysia. They both told the court that they were not guilty because they were manipulated to believe that the whole incident was a prank. Both the Indonesian and the Vietnamese governments hired lawyers to defend them, and they were found not guilty in court in 2019.

4.2.1 How the Media Represented Them

Immediately following the murder, both the international media and the public were intrigued by King Jong Nam's case; in particular, they all wanted to know more about Aisyah and Huong. After the security footage of the murder was released, most of the press started to address Huong as the "LOL assassin" due to the clothes she wore the day she assassinated Kim Jong Nam. The public discovered her social media page and learned of her previous appearance on the Vietnamese version of Pop Idol. *The Sun* reported these findings and noted that she "is a party-loving singer who posts sexy photos on her Facebook page" (Lockett, 2017).

Before these female "terrorists" were put on trial, early reports in the press suggested that Aisyah and Huong were trained assassins. *The Sun* quoted a Malaysian judge, who said that these two women "must answer for their role in the 'well-planned conspiracy'" (Birchall, 2017). *Belfast Telegraph* ("Women Accused," 2018) reported that Aisyah and Huong were thought to be "selected and trained individuals." The article continued on to hypothesize that it was possible for Aisyah and Huong to "lead a double life." One news report from *Daily Star* even suggested that Aisyah could have been a man "dressed as a woman for the attack" and described her and Huong as "a hit squad" (Trayner, 2017).

As their trials began and both women pleaded not guilty in 2018, the media turned its focus to their background stories and how they were manipulated. Most of the news reports analyzed in this paper dove into how their families stated and insisted that Aisyah and Huong were naïve and innocent young women who were duped by greater forces. The media noted that Aisyah was paid £72 for the job and that her friends even teased that she was going to be a

superstar on the reality show. In some reports, the media also described Kim Jong Nam as a “playboy” who was attracted to Huong before she attacked.

4.2.2 Frames and Stereotypes Behind the Reports and Why They Can Be Dangerous

When comparing the reports about these criminals before the trial and the reports that followed after their trial, a clear shift can be seen in how two different frames were used to represent Aisyah and Huong.

Before the trial, the frame used was the “dangerous, trained female assassin.” The media implied that Aisyah and Huong were professional assassins trained for this operation. After the trial, the media changed to reporting that the “duped and manipulated by vanity” frame. In later reports, the media focused on how these two women were duped into believing the assassination was a prank show because they were naïve and wanted to become famous.

These later frames are based on the traditional stereotypes about women being incapable of violence. The fact that the media reported extensively that Aisyah and Huong were trained assassins in the early stage demonstrated how people believe normal women would not and could not carry out assassinations. They had to have been specially trained and professional to fulfill their missions. The second frame is again reinforcing the idea that women are easily manipulated by males giving them a little amount of money or lies that they could become famous, presenting women as superficial.

The media’s extensive attention toward the two women in this case kept them from understanding the truth of this operation. Additionally, the media and the prosecutors fell into stereotyping frames that hindered arresting the true criminals. Although the police did hunt for four other North Korean males, who were thought to be the people who recruited and duped Aisyah and Huong, reports about these men by the media are far fewer than those about Aisyah and Huong. Perhaps if the media had focused on the four other male suspects of the murder in their investigations, more information would have surfaced about Kim Jong Nam’s death and less emotional harm would have been done to Aisyah and Huong, who were also victims.

4.3 The Case of Female Suicide Bombers of Boko Haram

Boko Haram, which translates to “Western Education Is A Sin,” is an extremist Islamic sect in Nigeria founded in 2002. Their aim is to wage war on the Federal Republic of Nigeria to create a pure Islamic State. From 2002 to 2011, Boko Haram incited riots, insurgencies, and bomb attacks, resulting in the deaths of thousands of people.

Boko Haram first started to deploy suicide bombers in 2011 and female suicide bombers in 2014, not only in Nigeria but also in neighboring nations such as Chad and Cameroon. Boko Haram's first female suicide bomber in June 2014 was a woman who drove a motorcycle and detonated herself while being searched at a checkpoint in Nigeria.

More female suicide bombers were deployed after that, including girls around the age of ten. Boko Haram is known for deploying more female suicide bombers than their fellow terrorist groups. Between 2011 and 2018, more than half of the bombers that targeted civilians in Nigeria, Cameroon, Chad, and Niger were women and girls.

Boko Haram is also known for its abduction of girls and women. The most famous case took place in 2014 when the group abducted about 270 school girls in Chibok. One of them later became the suspect in a suicide bombing case.

Although some were forced into acts of terrorism, there are still women who joined Boko Haram voluntarily due to financial instability, sexual discrimination, and patriarchal ideologies (International Crisis Group, 2016).

4.3.1 How the Media Represented Them

When Boko Haram deployed female suicide bombers in Nigeria starting in 2014, the media first hypothesized that this was because of a lack of male resources. In a BBC report (Chothia, 2014), a researcher with South Africa's Institute for Security Studies (ISS) said that the use of female bombers was a sign of the terrorist groups' desperation for personnel. Elizabeth

Pearson (2014) also suggested in *African Arguments* that Boko Haram had “depleted [its] male resources” and therefore recruits women as a “last resort.”

Early reports also focused on how these women and girls must have been brainwashed or forced into suicide bombing. One of the *Toronto Star* news reports (Searcey, 2016) wrote that “the women and girls who are deployed have been brainwashed or are simply unaware the devices they are carrying can kill them” (the explosives were often remotely detonated). In another article for the *New York Times* (2016), Dionne Searcey wrote that among the terrors Boko Haram brought, “one of the most baffling has been its ability to turn captured women and girls into killers.” *The Economist* (Lagos, 2017) noted that “some of the women may be willing if brainwashed, jihadists. Many, though, are believed to be coerced into strapping on bombs.”

Additionally, *The Economist* article noted that many Boko Haram women see becoming suicide bombers as a way to escape the abusive life of a Boko Haram fighter’s “wife.” *The New Humanitarian* (Ansbro, 2017) put forth similar thoughts. It reported that these women were “lured by the promise of a better life,” and, quoting Dr. Fatima Akilu, wrote that Boko Haram fighters “[are] like romantic characters for these women,” and “a lot of young girls actually aspire to marry Boko Haram fighters because they will have a much better life than other women.”

4.3.2 Frames and Stereotypes Behind the Reports and Why They Can Be Dangerous

The first frame in these reports, which can be summarized by Hien La and Selena Pickett’s (2019) “the vulnerable and helpless girls” frame, portrays women as weak and helpless who are incapable of choosing to participate in terrorism themselves but have to be forced into violent behaviors, which is not true in reality. It is rooted in stereotypes about how women must avoid engaging in violent actions or be seen as violent to stay caring and gentle (Mahmood, 2012).

The second frame is again the “duped and manipulated by vanity” frame, which suggests women are willing to become violent for money and social status. In Boko Haram’s case, it is

stereotyping women as desirous of romantic relationships and living a better life than other women.

By generalizing these Boko Haram female suicide bombers as “brainwashed,” the media neglects to report on the poverty and gender-inequality issues women in Nigeria face that spur them to join this group. After interviewing women rescued from Boko Haram, Adaobi Tricia Nwaubani (2017) found that women even returned to Boko Haram after they have been rescued or described their lives at Boko Haram as “fairytale-like” because they were able to receive expensive gifts and care from the terrorists. In their hometowns, they have to do extensive housework and have little to no social or economic status.

In the instances when women did have to be rescued from Boko Haram or escaped the group, the frame of generalizing female suicide bombers as “brainwashed” is dangerous for their reintegration efforts in new communities. They face stigmatization as they are called “Boko Haram wives” by their communities and are discriminated against for their past connection with Boko Haram (Faul, 2015).

5. Conclusion

Are motivations for women to become terrorists ultimately different than the motivations for men? Are women, like men, also moved by a set of complicated incentives including political ideologies and religions?

Researchers have begun to look into these questions. In her paper about the emergence of female terrorists and whether they have essential differences from their male counterparts, Speckhard (2008) found that women also act out of “trauma, revenge, nationalism, expression of community outrage,” and in non-conflict zones, they act out of “alienation, marginalization, negative self-identity, and a desire to act on behalf of those inside conflict zones.”

In 2016, Dionne Searcy wrote that Boko Haram had turned women and girls into killers in *New York Times* article, and she was subsequently criticized by her readers in the comments section for describing female suicide bombers as “terrorists.” According to readers,

these women and girls were clearly forced into becoming suicide bombers. One reader commented: “Also, I don’t think it’s right to call these women ‘terrorists,’ NYT.”

This commentary demonstrated how slow public opinion about female terrorists may be to change in light of so many years of biased reporting. How do journalists become ever more aware of how their words can impact individuals and communities, especially with generalizations and stereotypes about female terrorists?

Ultimately, the problem of terrorism in the world is far from over. Current counter-terrorism strategies, such as decreasing the utility of terrorist groups’ political power, rekindling stalled peace processes, and democracy promotion have proven ineffective in places such as Afghanistan and Syria, as they failed to engage with terrorist groups’ incentives and social utility. Instead, efforts can be taken to address how terrorist groups are facing alienation in society due to a lack of legislation, the underdevelopment of civil societies, or the lack of recognition of their identities (Abrahms, 2008). Women not only have the capability to help counter-terrorism actions but also have the ability to commit violence and pose threats to global security.

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Appendix A

The table below contains all the frames mentioned in this paper and their full explanations.

Proposer		Name of Frame	Explanation
Nacos	1	physical appearance frame	Focuses on female terrorists' physical features-their hair color, their eyes, and even their outfits-that contrast with the traditional image of a tough terrorist.
	2	family connection frame	Focuses more on female terrorists' family backgrounds than those of their male counterparts.
	3	"terrorists for the sake of love" frame	Focuses on women's romantic connections and claims women participate in terrorism for their husbands or lovers.
	4	"women's lib/equality" frame	Portrays female terrorists' activities as their defiance toward patriarchy, and "an unwelcome consequence of women's liberation movements."
	5	"tough-as-males/tougher-than-men" frame	Depicts female terrorists as not real women or in some cases, more ruthless and coldblooded than their male counterparts.

	6	“bored, naive, out-of-touch with reality” frame	Describes female terrorists as "non-political and clueless" of what their actions really mean.
Pierce	7	“feminized imagery” frame	Represents female suicide bombers and female self-immolators as “others” through headlines, photographs, and descriptive vernaculars.
	8	“violence breeds violence” frame	Used to “rationalize female violence” by suggesting female terrorists' behavior is “excusable because of [their] environment.”
	9	“Islamic honor” frame	Used to justify female violence by bringing up religion traditions of Islam, and the concepts of honor and shame.
	10	“manipulation and male control” frame	Focuses on the stereotype about women being pawns of men, “easily controlled by male manipulation, coercion, and restrictions” to explain female violence.
	11	“irrational women” frame	Used to “explain” how female terrorists are driven by irrationality including depression, desperations, and threat making.
Conway & McInerney	12	“liable agent” frame	Describes “these bombers as women who have control over their actions and thus should be held more personally responsible for what they have done.”
	13	“vulnerable and helpless girl” frame	Represents female terrorists as “being forced into these roles due to circumstances beyond their control.”
Naaman	14	“monster” frame	Alienates female terrorists by describing them as “monsters” and unfeminine.
	15	“brides” frame	Implying female terrorists’ connection with men and womanly sacrifice to explain their violence.

Raised in this paper	16	“sexual bait” frame	Focuses on how female terrorists use sex to appeal to men and how women should not be eager for sex unless asked by men.
	17	“narcissistic women” frame	Focuses on how female terrorists pay a lot of attention to their appearances and outfits, distracting them from their jobs.
	18	“dangerous, trained female assassin” frame	Stresses that women need to be well-trained to become terrorists.
	19	“duped and manipulated by vanity” frame	Focuses on how women are easily duped into committing violence for fame and vanity.